

Decorum in the Forum: Emotional Interactions in U.S. Presidential Press Conferences

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Introduction

In his final presidential press conference in 1953, President Truman discussed the idealistic notion of the conference as a public forum and institute of democracy, where the press can hold the president accountable:

This kind of news conference where reporters can ask any question they can dream up--directly to the President of the United States--illustrates how strong and how vital our democracy is. There is no other country in the world where the chief of state submits to such unlimited questioning. I know, too, from experience that it is not easy to stand up here and try to answer 'off the cuff' all kinds of questions without any advance notice. Perhaps succeeding Presidents will be able to figure out improvements and safeguards in the procedure. I hope they will never cut the direct line of communication between themselves and the people. (para. 4)

Presidential press conferences exist at the will of the president. When Theodore Roosevelt first invited the press into the White House, he exerted firm control over the rules of presidential press conferences (French, 1982). Presidential control over press conferences has relaxed over time, but the White House still maintains control of the location, timing, and participants. The press and the president are natural adversaries due to their competing interests: the president seeks to control the flow of information, and reporters strive to release as much information as possible as quickly as possible (Smith, 1990). In this paper, I explore this adversarial relationship through both parties' use of emotional language. I view presidential press conferences as a lopsided argumentative dialogue, with a unique kind of assumed decorum based on the one-sided relationship between the press and the president. The press can break this decorum through emotion-eliciting questions (pathotic appeals).

Argumentation in Presidential Press Conferences

Presidential press conferences are an argumentative environment. At first glance, they appear to be a kind of information-seeking dialogue; the press acts as arguers by questioning the president to explain his decisions or divulge information.¹ On further inspection, the discourse in a presidential press conference is multi-functional. The informational relationship is one-sided and adversarial; the president controls the flow of information. Additionally, the president engages in persuasive dialogue and acts as an arguer by producing persuasive answers that maintain his image. Finally, the press might be more interested in creating a story than just information; in this context, pathos plays an important role. A guide on hosting press conferences published by the U.S. General Services Administration (1988) gives a warning about the press:

Never argue with reporters or lose your cool. News people are always looking for an interesting story and may use whatever techniques they can to obtain one. Let your news, and not you, be the story. (p. 13)

The press can create eristic dialogue by seeking to aggravate and arouse emotion, and a successful press conference performance for the president involves avoiding these emotional appeals. Pathos is also an effective tool for the president to navigate a tough press conference. Smith (1990) discusses attributes of a good presidential answer and notes that Ronald Reagan's "good humor was probably his most effective asset in dealing with the press" (p. 116). Previous work that quantifies this adversarial relationship has focused on how press questions are constructed for dimensions such as assertiveness, directness, and initiative (Clayman & Heritage, 2002; Clayman et al., 2006). In this essay, I instead examine this adversarial relationship through both parties' use of pathos.

¹ Walton (2010) provides an overview of different dialogue types.

Methods

To explore the role of pathos in presidential press conferences, I collected 690 press conferences from the American Presidency Project, covering all 21st-century presidencies from Clinton to Biden.² I cleaned the collected transcripts and divided them into temporally ordered lists of utterances while maintaining speaker information. I adopt a model of pathos in natural language argumentation similar to Konat et al. (2024), where pathos is viewed as an interactional persuasive process of emotional appeals and reactions. This model allows for the convenient analysis of pathos using computational methods, and it also allows me to explore the strength of emotional appeals on different presidents and how the press uses emotion-eliciting language to achieve their goals. By focusing on emotion-eliciting language, I can examine which kinds of emotions the press uses the most in their emotional appeals, and whether it varies for different presidents. The president's emotion-eliciting language shows what kind of image the president is trying to maintain, and how this varies between presidents and their terms of office. Finally, the interactions between the press's emotion-eliciting language and the president's emotional reactions shows how successful different types of emotional appeal are on different presidents. I treat the press as a single speaker, but I track changes in the press's uses of language between presidential terms.

I identify emotion-eliciting language entirely using pre-existing lexicons that categorize words with an intensity score for seven basic emotions (anger, joy, anticipation, surprise, trust, disgust, fear) and a lexicon that gives each word a score for the Valence/Arousal/Dominance (VAD) model of emotion (Mohammad 2018a, 2018b). I do not introduce a labelling of emotion-eliciting words separate from these lexicons, and I acknowledge that any subjectivity in these original emotion scores will be present in my results. In the VAD model, words are given a score from 0 to 1 for their valence (positive to negative affect), arousal (calm to excited), and dominance (low control to high control). Figure 1 shows the various VAD scores given for words in a response to the press by President George W. Bush. We can observe that the president

² Sourced from: <https://www.presidency.ucsb.edu/statistics/data/presidential-news-conferences>, for this preliminary investigation, I focus only on the presidencies of presidents who served at least one term in the 21st century. Therefore whenever I refer to President Bush I am exclusively referring to President Bush Jr.

mostly uses high valence, high dominance words with moderate arousal, but also elicits negative emotion with his use of two words with significantly lower valence: “outdated” and “useless”.

First, I explore the use of emotional language and the emotional dynamics of the press and the president, utilizing lexicons for the VAD model and individual emotions. I collect an average of the emotional score for every utterance from the president and the press along the VAD model for each presidential term. I also perform paired t-tests between the scores of these utterances to check if there is any statistical significance to the difference between the president's and the press's emotional averages. Emotional dynamics involves computing metrics around each speaker's use of emotion-eliciting language over time (Hipson & Mohammad, 2021; Vishnubhotla & Mohammad, 2022). For example, using a lexicon of words with a score for anger, I compute the average baseline anger value for the press's language and how this differs

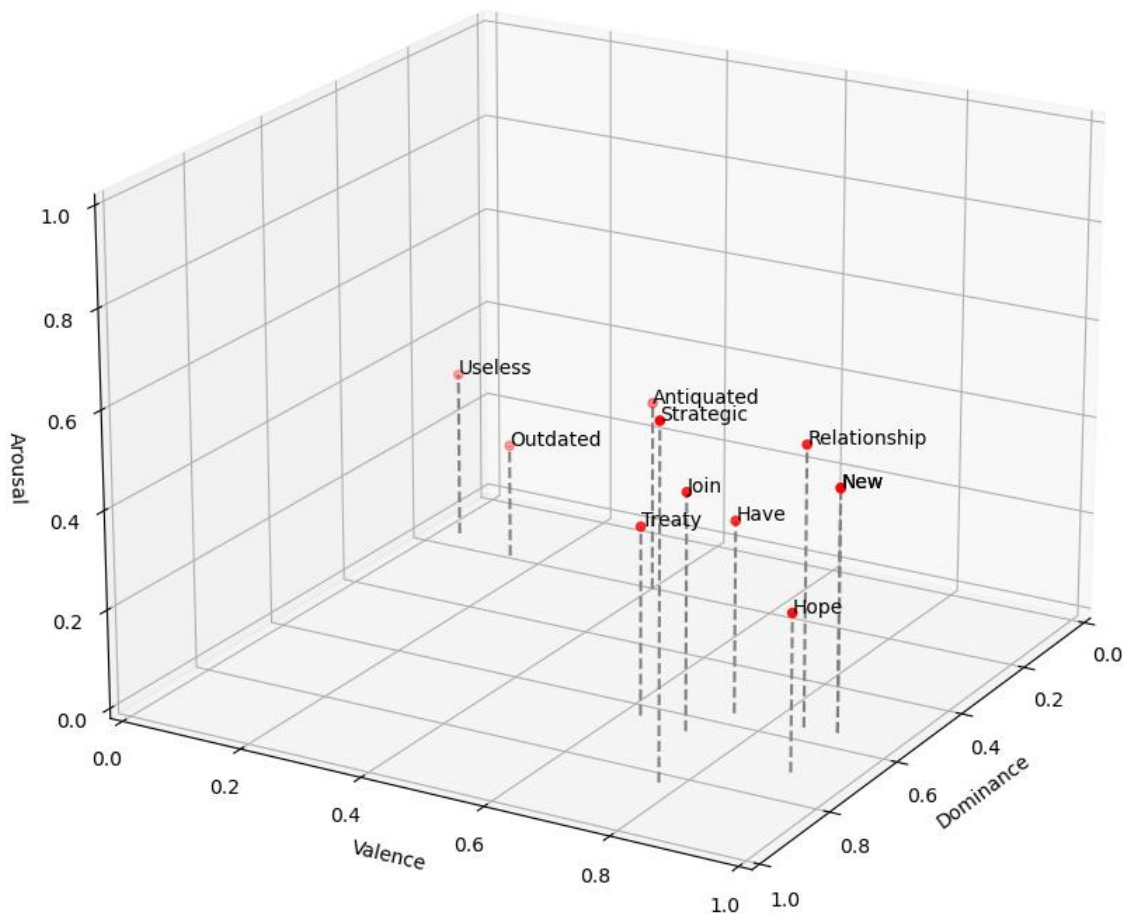


Figure 1: VAD scores for a response by President Bush given in 2001: “I have told Mr. Putin that the ABM Treaty is outdated, antiquated, and useless. And I hope that he will join us in a new strategic relationship”. Not all words have a VAD score in existing lexicons, and some words which we might not immediately consider emotional do have a score, such as “Have” in the example above.

from the president's baseline, and how often and by how much the press and the president use language that displaces them from their respective baseline. I use the length and strength of these displacements to identify utterances that contain an uptick in the use of emotion-eliciting language compared to the speaker's standard usage.

Second, I analyze the emotional interactions between the press and the president. To analyze emotional interactions, I examine emotion-eliciting language in press utterances and the emotion-expressing reactions by the president in their responding utterances. Emotion-eliciting language is identified from the same lexicons used in the emotional dynamics analysis. Emotion expression by the president is identified by applying a pre-trained model for classifying text into one of five basic emotions and a neutral class (anger, joy, sadness, disgust, fear, neutral).³ I check both how the president responds to any emotional question, as well as how they respond to specific emotions.⁴ In both cases, I perform a chi-square test of independence between the emotional nature of the question and the response to check if there is a dependent relationship between them.

Results

Computing the average VAD score of the words used by the press and the president across different presidential terms shows that the use of emotional language differs between the press and the president. Across most presidential terms, these differences persist, suggesting that the president and the press generally fall into their roles, with the press as an antagonist. The difference in VAD scores between the president and the press in each presidential term is small but statistically significant ($P < 0.05$). Figure 2 shows that the arousal of the words of the press and the president is low, with the press having slightly higher arousal than the president. Furthermore, the press persistently has a lower valence (more negative language) than the president, although it is slightly positive. Noticeably, the gap in valence between the press and the president widens at the start of President Bush's first term and has been narrowing since then,

³ Jochen Hartmann, "Emotion English DistilRoBERTa-base". <https://huggingface.co/j-hartmann/emotion-english-distilroberta-base/>, 2022. The surprise label is filtered out for my experiments.

⁴ When I refer to an 'emotional question', I mean a question that contains a displacement in emotion-eliciting language (based on pre-existing lexicons) for any kind of emotion from the press. When I refer to the primary emotion of these questions, or the emotion these questions are rooted in, I refer to the emotion that had the strongest displacement from its baseline.

with both the press becoming more positive and the president becoming more negative. For most presidents, the dominance of the language used by the president is higher than the press. However, the dominance of the language used by President Trump is noticeably lower than other presidents and falls below that of the press.

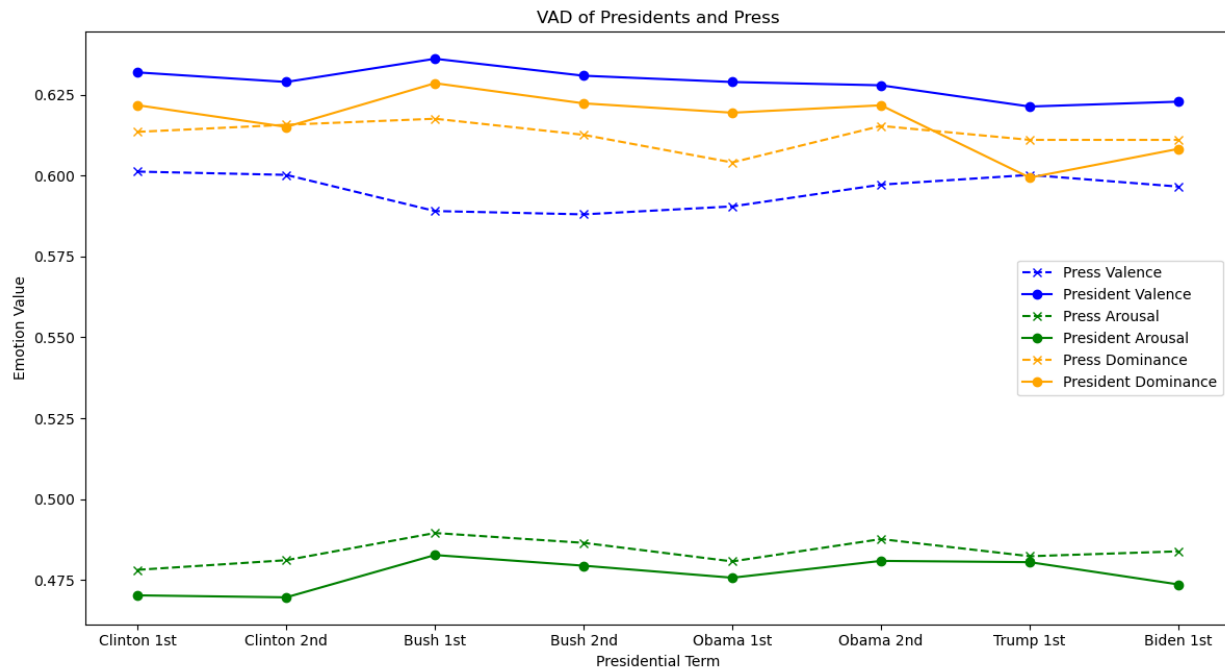


Figure 2: Mean emotional scores for the VAD of utterances from the president and the press across different presidential terms.

To explore emotional interactions between the president and the press, I first wanted to gauge how effective emotional questions from the press are at arousing a response, or whether the president expresses their emotions independent of the question asked. Firstly, I found that most responses by the president to any question from the press are neutral; Obama's second term is the highest, with 83% of responses being neutral, and Trump's first term is the lowest at 72%. When considering only those questions that include emotional language, I observe a very slight drop in neutral responses in some presidents (1-3%). Obama's second term remains the highest at 83% neutral responses, but Trump's first term drops to 69%. This suggests that, in general, presidents produce neutral expressions and ignore the emotion-eliciting language of the press's questions. Furthermore, performing a dependence test between any emotional question/response and any neutral question/response does not produce any statistically significant results for most of the presidents, and so the independence of emotion-eliciting language and the emotional

response of the president cannot be ruled out. This suggests that emotional language alone is not enough to identify if the emotional expressions of the president are caused by emotional appeals from the press. Either the press does not have this relationship with the president, or more advanced methods might be needed to measure their interaction. The only exception to this is President Bush, who does have a weak but statistically significant dependence: when the press asks Bush an emotional question, he is more likely to respond emotionally.

Examining just those emotional interactions that involve an emotional question and response, we can observe some interesting patterns in the use of pathos by the press. Figure 3 shows heatmaps of emotional questions and responses. Noticeably, the questions the press uses that evoke an emotional response to various presidents tend to be those rooted in fear.⁵ Like emotional questions/responses in general, no presidents, except for Bush, have a statistically significant dependence between the specific elicited emotion in the question and the specific expressed emotion in their response. One notable observation is that for all presidents except Trump, the most common emotional response to a question primarily rooted in fear-eliciting language is also fear. However, for Trump, he mostly responds to fear with disgust.

⁵ In these emotional questions, the strongest displacement from the press's baseline in the scores of emotion-eliciting language was from the fear scores of words.

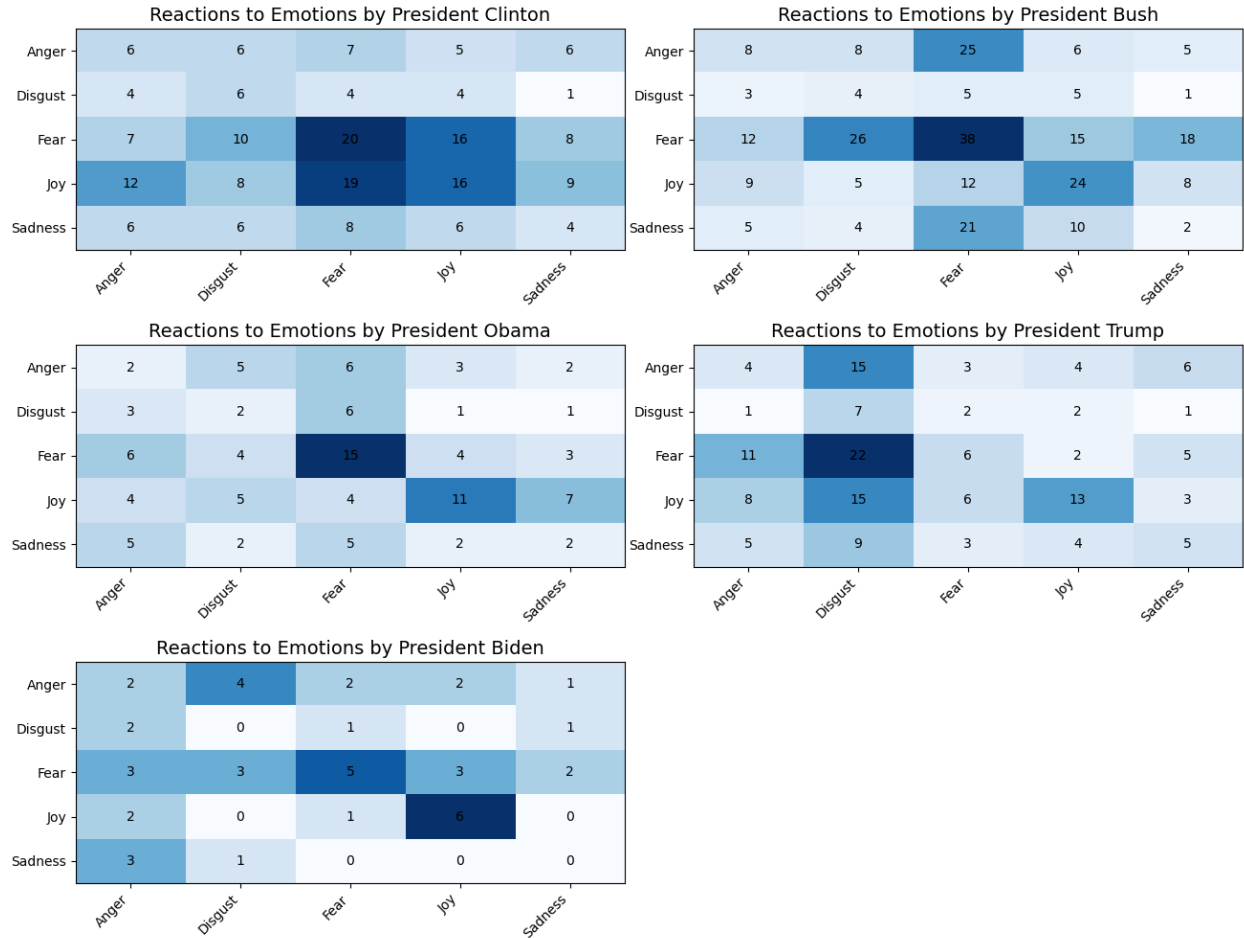


Figure 2: Heatmaps of emotional interactions between the president and the press. The y-axis of each heatmap is the peak emotion expressed in the language given by the press, and the x-axis is the expressed emotion in the president's response. Neutral interactions are excluded.

Discussion and Future Work

In this paper, I have explored how the use of emotion-eliciting language can be used to identify the roles of participants in a dialogue, and the success of their pathotic appeals. The computational methods used are based on pre-existing lexicons and models and so are easy to implement for other datasets. My approach has the potential to provide useful insights into the use of emotional argumentation in a dialogue.

I was able to show that on the VAD model of emotions, the president and the press exhibit small but statistically significant differences that generally persist across different presidential terms. This suggests that by solely looking at the emotional words used in an

adversarial dialogue, we may be able to identify distinct roles in the participants. For emotional interaction, I was able to find that for President Bush, emotion-expression in his responses was dependent on emotion-eliciting language in the questions. The most pervasive emotional language used in questions was fear, and most presidents responded with fear to fear-based questions. However, I did not find a dependent relationship (in general) between emotion-eliciting language in questions by the press and emotion-expression in responses from the president. This could mean that the presidents maintain composure and express emotions independently of the press's questioning. Alternatively, it might be the case that just examining emotion-eliciting language is not enough to capture emotional appeals in conversation.

In the future, I would like to explore more rigorous computational methods for identifying emotion cause and effect in conversation. It would be more accurate (and challenging) to identify the specific utterances that caused an expression of emotion rather than just assuming that only the preceding utterance caused the expression of emotion; emotion cause-pair extraction in conversation (ECPEC) is a relatively new computational task that aims to do just this (Li et al., 2023), and results from ECPEC could be used to identify potent questions that caused several emotional expressions throughout the conversation. This paper has also only explored interactions between the press and the president. However, the relationship between the press secretary and the press has also shifted with each president. It would be interesting to explore further how interactions between the press secretary and the press compare to those between the president and the press.

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